

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 72

Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1974

Coverage Date: 1960-1974

Place Coverage: Zimbabwe

Section Title(S): 2.0. Personal Praises

2.10. The praises of women are love poems, **madétémbédzo ókupfimbáná** 'praises for courtship'.

[5310](#)
[Verbal Arts](#)

[831](#)
[Sexuality](#)

2.11. The poems in praise of women that young men use in order to woo their sweethearts show a certain similarity of phrasing in that the same lines, chosen from a traditional stock in circulation, recur again and again. The following are examples.

[5310](#)
[Verbal Arts](#)

[831](#)
[Sexuality](#)

Váchírérannerera.

Muné mwóyochéna unéngé wetsóro

inórirítíra vaná vasívayo.

Muné kupá kunéngé kuramwa;

Vánzungú-nhókotera,

Matékwé-ndíriní.

'Guardian of orphans.

You have a heart generous as that of the honey-guide
which cares for children other than its own.

You give as another might cast away out of pique;

Kernel of the nut,

While I am its shell.'

[5310](#)
[Verbal Arts](#)

[831](#)
[Sexuality](#)

2.12. However, young men do try to make certain parts of their courtship praises fresh, original, and striking. It is something that they have been used to working at from childhood up, from the days of **mahúmbwe** 'keeping house', and from the dances and songs of childhood such as **Sarúrá wákó**, **kadeyadeya** 'Choose one of your own choice, as a dove next to its mate'. The fact that each girl is a different person with her own individual charms obviously evokes different lines and different conceits.

5310
Verbal Arts

533
Music

535
Dance

Runyemwerero rwákó rwúíté semhéni,
Úmwékúkire kusúma rufáro rwákó kunení.

5310
Verbal Arts

Zvindípe ruvimbo sézvinóita mhúpúpú pámunhúrukwa,

533
Music

Ndídádé newé pányika kuvanhu.
'Let your smile flash like lightning,
Beam on me to introduce me into the presence of your joy.
And let it give me hope as the rain-bird in the summer,
So that I may walk in pride before all the people in the country.'

535
Dance

2.13. The most mature love poetry appears to be that composed during marriage. In the examples collected the praises form part of the licensed banter between ritual friends. Each one praises his own wife for her qualities and criticizes the wife of his friend. The qualities which are praised are those that husbands would like to see in all women, mainly generosity, hard work, and cleanliness. But beauty and grace are not neglected.

5310
Verbal Arts

585
Nuptials

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)